operated from absolute ignorance about the fact that India did not need to place orders with companies which we had incubated.

Unfortunately, to take forward the plot, constant comparisons were made to link percentage of India's population vaccinated to percentages of other western nations running vaccination drives, despite the fact that India had administered more vaccine doses than all other countries by June 2020. But considering the vastness of our population, our percentage of population vaccinated would remain low as compared to nations with significantly lesser population. Running such conniving stories at the peak of a ghastly second wave was bringing the morale of the people down. The narrative in the media was so bitter that several world leaders stood up to defend India's vaccine policies. France's President Emmanuel Macron, in the presence of 26 EU nations at the India-EU virtual summit held during the peak of the wave, said, 'India does not need to be "lectured from anyone" on vaccine supplies. India has exported a lot for humanity to many countries. We know what situation India is in.'[44] The UN Secretary António Guterres was also prompted to tweet, 'I think the [vaccine] production capacity of India is the best asset that the world has today. I hope the world understands that it must be fully used.'[45]

Now, even as NEGVAC planned the vaccine drive, way back in the month of November, they were in full knowledge of the fact that the production of vaccines in India was going to be heavily back loaded. For the first seven months of the year, we would be seeing about 60 crore doses while over the remainder of the five months of 2021, we would have enough supplies to inoculate our entire population with both doses. However, 10 chief ministers of opposition-ruled states wrote to the prime minister several times, urging him to decentralize vaccine procurement. NEGVAC had been in talks with all vaccine manufacturers in India as well as over the world since mid-2020. By virtue of actual experience, they knew that opening up procurement would not yield any positive results. None of the vaccine manufacturers, who were coveted entities by several countries, would engage in procurement discussions on state levels. It wasn't going to happen. But owing to the constant pressure from the opposition parties, the government conceded and allowed state governments to procure vaccines. After a rough few weeks, where the tenders floated by states didn't attract any supplies, the same chief ministers who earlier forced the prime minister to open up procurement, made a U-turn asking the